

# UEFA Nations League

UEFA introduced the Nations League to replace many international friendlies with competitive league matches. The highest-ranked teams compete for a place in the Nations League Finals.

## UEFA Nations League Finals, 2018-19 onward

| Season                  | Finals host | Winner                   | Runner-up | Third  | Fourth  | Final                     | Final date  | Story                                                                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------|-------------|--------------------------|-----------|--------|---------|---------------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">2024-25</a> | Germany     | <a href="#">Portugal</a> | Spain     | France | Germany | 2-2;<br>Portugal 5-3 pens | 8 June 2025 | <div><div>►📖 Tap to read the story</div><div>Portugal beat Spain on penalties in the 2025 final to become the competition's first two-time champion.</div></div> |

| Season         | Finals host | Winner                 | Runner-up | Third | Fourth      | Final               | Final date      | Story                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------|-------------|------------------------|-----------|-------|-------------|---------------------|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <u>2022-23</u> | Netherlands | <a href="#">Spain</a>  | Croatia   | Italy | Netherlands | 0-0; Spain 5-4 pens | 18 June 2023    | <p>►  Tap to read the story</p> <p>Spain won the 2023 final on penalties after a goalless draw with Croatia.</p>                                               |
| <u>2020-21</u> | Italy       | <a href="#">France</a> | Spain     | Italy | Belgium     | France 2-1 Spain    | 10 October 2021 | <p>►  Tap to read the story</p> <p>Italy hosted the 2021 Finals without reaching the final itself, finishing third as France beat Spain 2-1 for the title.</p> |

| Season         | Finals host | Winner          | Runner-up   | Third   | Fourth      | Final                    | Final date  | Story                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------|-------------|-----------------|-------------|---------|-------------|--------------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <u>2018-19</u> | Portugal    | <u>Portugal</u> | Netherlands | England | Switzerland | Portugal 1-0 Netherlands | 9 June 2019 | <p>►  Tap to read the story</p> <p>Portugal won the first-ever Nations League Finals in 2019, beating Netherlands 1-0 as hosts.</p> |

## Podium by edition

### 2024-25

Hosted by Germany

 **Portugal**

 Spain

 France

4. Germany

### 2022-23

Hosted by Netherlands

 **Spain**

 Croatia

 Italy

4. Netherlands

### 2020-21

Hosted by Italy

 **France**

 Spain

 Italy

4. Belgium

## 2018-19

Hosted by Portugal

 **Portugal**

 Netherlands

 England

4. Switzerland

## Champions by titles

Generated automatically from the edition table above. Totals group a nation with its sporting predecessor only where the source content does (Germany includes West Germany); every other name is counted as written.

### Portugal

2

2018-19, 2024-25

### France

1

2020-21

### Spain

1

2022-23

## Where the tournament has been hosted

Every host country's approximate location on a simple latitude/longitude grid, grouped by region in the list below - not a claim of exact borders, just roughly where in the world each edition took place. Bigger dots hosted more than once.



## Europe

**Portugal** 1 time

2018-19

**Italy** 1 time

2020-21

**Netherlands** 1 time

2022-23

**Germany** 1 time

2024-25

## How it works

- Every UEFA national team is placed into one of four leagues (A to D) by strength, then split into small groups within its league.
- Teams play each other in their group; results promote the best teams to a higher league and relegate the weakest to a lower one, alongside separate World Cup/EURO qualifying.

- The four League A group winners advance to the Nations League Finals: two semifinals, a third-place match, and a final, all hosted by one of the four finalists.
- Held every two years.

### **Key facts**

- Portugal won the inaugural edition.
- Portugal became the first two-time champion in 2025.
- Croatia reached its first Nations League final in 2023.
- The competition uses promotion and relegation between leagues.

### **Final venues**

- All four teams that reach the Nations League Finals host a semifinal, but only one stadium in the host nation stages the final itself. A reported attendance figure is added only where it could be confirmed via two independent sources (2019 so far) - the other three editions' figures could not be reliably cross-checked and are left out rather than guessed.
- **2019:** Estádio do Dragão, Porto (Portugal) - a reported attendance of 43,199.
- **2021:** San Siro, Milan (Italy).
- **2023:** De Kuip, Rotterdam (Netherlands) - stepped in for the larger Johan Cruyff Arena in Amsterdam, which was unavailable because of a concert booking.
- **2025:** Allianz Arena, Munich (Germany).

### **Player of the Finals winners**

- UEFA has named a best-player award at every Nations League Finals since the competition's 2019 launch, initially called "Player of the Tournament" before being renamed "Player of the Finals" from 2021 onward.
- **2019:** Bernardo Silva (Portugal).
- **2021:** Sergio Busquets (Spain).
- **2023:** Rodri (Spain).
- **2025:** Nuno Mendes (Portugal).

## **Winning managers**

- **2019:** Fernando Santos (Portugal).
- **2021:** Didier Deschamps (France).
- **2023:** Luis de la Fuente (Spain) - the same season he took charge of Spain, before also winning EURO 2024 and the 2026 World Cup with them.
- **2025:** Roberto Martínez (Portugal) - his first trophy since taking over from Fernando Santos.

## **Winning captains**

- The captain is the player who lifts the trophy on the podium; every Nations League Finals winner has had one across all four completed editions.
- **2019:** Cristiano Ronaldo (Portugal).
- **2021:** Hugo Lloris (France).
- **2023:** Jordi Alba (Spain) - given the captaincy for the Finals by manager Luis de la Fuente.
- **2025:** Cristiano Ronaldo (Portugal) - the first captain to lift the Nations League trophy twice.

## **Memorable moments**

- Portugal won the first-ever Nations League Finals in 2019, beating Netherlands 1-0 as hosts.
- Italy hosted the 2021 Finals without reaching the final itself, finishing third as France beat Spain 2-1 for the title.
- Spain won the 2023 final on penalties after a goalless draw with Croatia.
- Portugal beat Spain on penalties in the 2025 final to become the competition's first two-time champion.
- The host nation has finished in the Finals' top four in every edition so far, including Germany finishing fourth in 2025.

## **References & review**

**Status: verified**

Last reviewed: 10 September 2026

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- Final venues (added 2026-09-09, eighty-ninth intensive run): a new "Final (source 10 of 10)" (<https://www.euronews.com/2025/06/08/portugal-beats-spain-to-win-the-nations-league>).
- Final attendance investigation (added 2026-09-10, ninety-fourth intensive (source 1 of 5)) ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2019\\_UEFA\\_Nations\\_League\\_final](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2019_UEFA_Nations_League_final)).
- Final attendance investigation (added 2026-09-10, ninety-fourth intensive (source 2 of 5)) (<https://www.zerozero.pt/jogo/2019-06-09-portugal-paises-baixos/6894430>).
- Final attendance investigation (added 2026-09-10, ninety-fourth intensive (source 3 of 5)) ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2021\\_UEFA\\_Nations\\_League\\_final](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2021_UEFA_Nations_League_final)).
- Final attendance investigation (added 2026-09-10, ninety-fourth intensive (source 4 of 5)) ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2023\\_UEFA\\_Nations\\_League\\_final](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2023_UEFA_Nations_League_final)).
- Final attendance investigation (added 2026-09-10, ninety-fourth intensive (source 5 of 5)) ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2025\\_UEFA\\_Nations\\_League\\_final](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2025_UEFA_Nations_League_final)).
- Final attendance re-investigation (added 2026-09-10, ninety-sixth intensive (source 1 of 6)) ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2021\\_UEFA\\_Nations\\_League\\_final](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2021_UEFA_Nations_League_final)).
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- Final attendance re-investigation (added 2026-09-10, ninety-sixth intensive (source 6 of 6)) ([https://muenchen.t-online.de/region/muenchen/id\\_101224878/muenchen-dfb-team-bestreitet-nations-league-spiel-in-der-allianz-arena.html](https://muenchen.t-online.de/region/muenchen/id_101224878/muenchen-dfb-team-bestreitet-nations-league-spiel-in-der-allianz-arena.html)).

Primary sources are preferred. Historical formats and team names are recorded as used at the time; see each edition's notes for context.